

German paybook
A *Soldbuch* was carried by every member of the German army. It contained a record of the soldier's pay and home leave, unit information, equipment issued, and medical records.

artillery bombardment for four hours, British front-line troops were overrun by German stormtroopers as they emerged out of thick morning fog. Once the Germans were at close quarters, there was no resisting their flamethrowers, grenades, and submachine-guns. In some places, stormtroopers advanced 16km (10 miles) in a day's fighting and 65km (40 miles) by the end of a week, an achievement unprecedented since the trench lines had solidified in late 1914. But in other parts of the front the German offensive failed or made little progress. The Kaiserschlacht gained the Germans territory but not overall victory, and completed the exhaustion of their army.

BITTER DEFEAT

As a result of the conscription of farm workers and farm horses, Germany was desperately short of food by 1918, and German soldiers could not be insulated from these shortages. At Easter, one soldier complained that his day's rations had consisted of half a loaf of bread and a chunk of roasted horsemeat. The March offensive was disrupted when German soldiers overran Allied stores brimming with food and drink, which they stopped to plunder and enjoy. Their poor diet left them very susceptible to the deadly flu epidemic that erupted in the second half of 1918.

Worse than hunger and sickness for the German soldiers, however, was the certainty that they could no longer win the war as American troops arrived in force. When the Allies drove them back in a series of well-planned offensives from the late summer, German soldiers began to surrender. Most never gave up, however, and they remained on foreign soil at the armistice. Many Germans could not accept they had been defeated after such a titanic struggle, which had cost around two million soldiers their lives. While most ex-servicemen became staunchly anti-war as a result of their experiences, a substantial minority recreated the comradeship of the trenches in nationalist paramilitary organizations. The memory of the stormtroopers was later perverted by the Nazi Party in search of a warrior myth to justify aggressive militarism.

INFILTRATION TACTICS

The Germans sought to end the dominance of defence on the World War I battlefield by tactics designed to penetrate enemy lines rapidly and in depth. First used to full effect by General von Hutier at Riga in September 1917, infiltration tactics dispensed with a prolonged preliminary bombardment of enemy trenches. Instead, a "hurricane" artillery barrage of great intensity, but short duration, was followed by the advance of heavily-armed stormtroopers. Bypassing strongpoints, these elite troops would overrun weaker points in front-line trenches with the force of their shock attack. They then pressed on swiftly through second- and third-line trenches to threaten enemy artillery and communications. Assault infantry would follow immediately behind them cleaning up pockets of resistance such as machine-gun nests. Although infiltration tactics often succeeded in their objective of punching a hole in enemy lines, they did not solve the problem of exploiting the opportunity thus presented. In the absence of motor vehicles, any advance soon slowed to a crawl because of insuperable logistical and transport problems.



Stick grenade
The *Stielhandgranate*, or stick grenade, was synonymous with the stormtroopers' rapid assaults on enemy lines.

Last line of defence
Almost deserted, this German soldier stands in his trench about to deal one last attack on the advancing enemy.

Gas mask
The German army's means of protection from gas attacks was more sophisticated than the Allies' goggles and cotton wadding. This mask features a cylindrical screw-fitted air filter.

